of the AP Capital Region Development Authority (APCRDA), the government agency executing the capital project, its commissioner Vijay Rama Raju says the target is to complete work on all the iconic buildings, assembly, high court and GAD-HoD towers, and have them ready for inauguration by August 2028. "Other key components like housing and buildings, including the bungalows of ministers and judges, will be readied by September 2026, the trunk infrastructure by December 2026, and the land pooling infrastructure by October 2027." Land pooling infrastructure refers to the infra development in the expanse earmarked for the 71,342 plots to be handed over to farmers.

The mid-2028 target, if met with, or even overshot by a few months, will hand Naidu and his Telugu Desam Party ample time to showcase his dream project to the public before the 2029 election. The CM has been conducting regular reviews, constantly pushing everyone to move faster. When INDIA TODAY met Naidu at his chambers after visiting the construction sites, the 76-year-old four-time CM was eager for feedback. "Yes, the pace needs to improve at some sites and in few aspects. We will do it," the man who transformed Hyderabad into a global tech hub says.

Currently, the heavy-steel advanced diagrid structure forming the frame and support of the GAD-HoD towers has reached the seventh-storey level. "Every new floor is taking 15 days' time," says Ankamma Choudary, superintending engineer, APCRDA. "The target is to bring it down to 10 days."

THE SPECTRE OF MAVIGUN

What is looming large is not just the 2028 deadline but also a new capital area—MaViGun—that bete noire Jagan has proposed, disconcerting Naidu. The former CM is rooting for a capital corridor connecting the port town of Machilipatnam with Vijayawada and Guntur, all within a 110-km range, which he says will considerably reduce the "wasteful expenditure" on Amaravati. It is a narrowed-down version of Jagan's old decentralised three-capital formula, except that Amaravati lies outside it. And this when Parliament passed an amendment to the Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation Act, 2014, this April, according Amaravati the statutory status of being the sole and permanent capital.

Jagan is hell-bent on pursuing MaViGun and making it key to his agenda for the 2029 election. The Naidu government, he intends to demonstrate, is spending way too much money and time to develop a new greenfield capital, "which the state cannot afford". According to the YSRCP, as much as Rs 20,497 per sq. ft is being spent on the secretariat. Charging Naidu with massive corruption, Jagan is pitching MaViGun as a more viable alternative "as it already has strong infrastructure, including port, highways, rail and air connectivity".

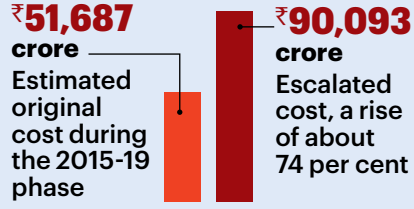
YSRCP is also accusing Naidu of expanding the acreage for Amaravati: After amassing nearly 54,000 acres, including about 35,000 acres from farmers, Naidu is going for another 50,000 acres, taking the total to close to a 100,000 acres. "Based on the government's own estimates of nearly Rs 2 crore per acre for basic infrastructure alone, one lakh acres would require nearly Rs 2 lakh crore even before constructing the assembly, secretariat, high court and institutional buildings," says a YSRCP note.

While a second phase of land pooling is indeed currently under way, APCRDA officials say the land being procured in seven more villages amounts to approximately 16,666 acres. "This is earmarked for an International Sports City, a new railway station and the Inner Ring Road," says Raju. Disputing YSRCP's Rs 2 lakh crore figure, the APCRDA puts the cost of basic infrastructure (drainage, roads, electricity, flood protection and amenities) at Rs 48,717 crore for the present project expanse. Naidu attributes Jagan's corruption charges to the YSRCP leader's "frustration and inability to accept Amaravati works progressing well, and development taking place". Branding Jagan's "invention" of MaViGun as "crazy", Naidu has said publicly that the Opposition leader was unwilling to even utter the word Amaravati, which the TDP supremo dubs "*devatala-rajadhani*" (capital/abode of gods). In the AP Progress Report 2024-26, Naidu said Amaravati was planned as a self-financing model, with the total project cost pegged at Rs 51,687 crore. With the project hanging fire during YSRCP rule, the overall cost, APCRDA officials say, has risen to Rs 90,093 crore over the decade.

After all the money already spent, the next two years will determine whether a project conceived more than a decade ago finally becomes a capital befitting Andhra Pradesh. ■

THE COST OF AMARAVATI

THE SPEND



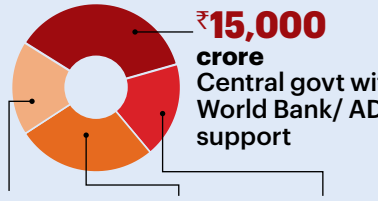
THE PROGRESS SO FAR

₹60,100 crore
Worth of projects tendered

₹58,415 crore
Worth of projects awarded

THE FUNDING

₹40,887 crore — Finance secured for 67 projects



₹7,500 crore NaBFID

₹11,000 crore HUDCO

₹7,387 crore NABARD

Completion target
Aug. 2028

Figures are rounded off